

# You've stopped bringing up the facts because you're sure it will only make them dig in

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

Deciding it's hopeless is easier than working out what to say differently. Correcting someone rarely makes a false belief worse: what you say once you finally do **decides whether it lands**.

## THE GOAL

Give them one clear, complete version of what's true instead of just saying they're wrong, and **let it sit**.

## CHECKLIST

**They just brought it up again, right in front of you, and you're about to let it go like you usually do.**

- ☐ Let them finish saying it before you respond.
- ☐ Get the sequence from them: what came first, and what happened right after that?
- ☐ Listen to their whole account without correcting any part of it yet.
- ☐ Name out loud the one part of what they said that is actually true.
- ☐ State your correction in a single sentence, not a list of several.
- ☐ Follow your correction immediately with what you believe actually happened, not only with what's wrong in theirs.
- ☐ Say the true version in whichever order feels natural, before or after mentioning their claim.
- ☐ If they argue back right away, say one closing line, like "I just wanted you to have it," and stop for today.
- ☐ If they go quiet or change the subject, let the moment end there; that is not a sign it didn't count.
- ☐ Before you leave the room, write down the one true fact you just gave them, somewhere you'll see it again.
- ☐ Before the conversation ends, pick an actual day in the next few weeks to **bring the true version up again**.
- ☐ If you don't have a fact ready, say so, and come back to the correction later that same day rather than guessing.

## THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** If it didn't stick before, that's not proof they're unreachable. A flat 'wrong' rarely replaces the story they already had.
- 2** A person's trust in you counts for more than a stranger's fact-check or an unfamiliar expert's credentials.
- 3** A correction that lands today can fade from memory over time, letting the old belief **creep back**.

## Why staying quiet doesn't actually protect anyone

### KNOW

If it didn't stick before, that's not proof they're unreachable. A flat 'wrong' rarely replaces the story they already had.

A bare denial **leaves a gap** where their explanation used to be, so give the full alternative account instead, not just the correction. [Source 1](#)

**DON'T**

Fearing they'll 'dig in' usually protects you from a hard conversation more than it predicts anything about their mind.

A major review of the evidence kept failing to find that effect, even when researchers tried hard to produce it. [Source 1](#)

**KNOW**

Holding a conspiracy-style belief isn't rare. About half of people, across four surveys, said yes to at least one.

So it isn't a rare case needing a special moment, closer to the everyday version of this problem than it feels. [Source 5](#)

## What actually gets through

**SAY**

Ask them a single question instead of arguing: walk through it, what happened first, then what?

Most people's sense of how well they understand something drops once they try explaining the mechanism out loud. [Source 4](#)

**KNOW**

A person's trust in you counts for more than a stranger's fact-check or an unfamiliar expert's credentials.

It's worth being the person who says it, since who says something matters more than how much they know. [Source 3](#)

**DON'T**

Don't worry about whether to repeat their claim first. Order barely matters if the full explanation gets said.

Several tested formats made little difference to belief in the false claim, and what mattered was whether the full explanation got said. [Source 7](#)

## Reading their reaction without fooling yourself

**KNOW**

Deciding they're simply irrational if they don't fold is tempting. That read is itself a well-documented bias.

We tend to assume our own take is objective, and that whoever sees it differently must be missing something. [Source 2](#)

**KNOW**

A correction that lands today can fade from memory over time, letting the old belief **creep back**.

Repeating the true version later helps it stick, because a faded memory of the correction lets the false version return. [Source 3](#)

## Myths worth retiring

**MYTH**

**Get them to explain, in detail, exactly how their belief would have to work, and their overall view will soften up.**

**ACTUALLY**

Explaining the mechanism in detail doesn't reliably soften a person's overall view. A later, larger attempt to reproduce that exact result found the softening **didn't show up again**. [Source 6](#)

## Sources

1. [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Backfire\\_effect](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Backfire_effect)
2. [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Na%C3%AFve\\_realism\\_\(psychology\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Na%C3%AFve_realism_(psychology))
3. <https://www.emc-lab.org/uploads/1/1/3/6/113627673/prike.2023.copp.pdf>
4. <https://psycnet.apa.org/record/2013-20507-014>
5. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/24363536>
6. <https://gwern.net/doc/psychology/cognitive-bias/illusion-of-depth/2022-sloman.pdf>
7. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8715407/>

## Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on When someone close believes something false at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)